

Minutes of Neighborhood Meeting of the West End Civic Association

March 13, 2025

Attendance

- **WECA Officers:** Margaret Magner, President; Ajay Khetarpal, Vice President; Heidi Liu, Vice President for Outreach; Darlene Pierro, Treasurer; Duane Rollins, Corresponding Secretary; Angela Geer, Recording Secretary
- **WECA Block Captains:** Noreen Bryan, Rick Mui, Jane Pontius, Brian Shipley
- **Others Attending:** John Barker, Katharine Carman, Scott Carman, Jim Donohue, Lauren Eggbeer, Brian Geary, Kim Geary, Anika Halota, Jack Kelly, Sara Kiesler, Thomas Kim, Erin Mahony, Kevin Mansheim, Jenn Myers, Melissa Opryszko, James Pontius, Jacalyn Queen, Kim Queen, Elizabeth Rizza, Meghan Rosen, Paul Rosenfeld, Tracy Saltwell, Eric Schneider, Ken Sonner, Lindsay West

Call to Order/Welcome

- The meeting took place in-person at the Rockville Presbyterian Church meeting room and online via Zoom. President Margaret Magner called the meeting to order at 7:05pm. She thanked the Rockville Presbyterian Church for the use of their space for decades for WECA meetings.

News and Information

- **Rockville Presbyterian Church (RPC): Changing Real Estate Landscape**
 - Pastor Susan Graceson expressed gratitude for the partnership with WECA and mentioned the church's current period of dynamic transition, emphasizing transparency and community impact.
 - Pat Wolff, RPC Clerk of Session, provided a historical overview of the church, its buildings, and its governance structure. Pat explained the church's decision to explore options for the ED (Education) building, including renting, selling, or leasing it, and the hiring of a professional real estate agent.
 - The building was listed for lease or sale in January, attracting significant interest. They are in the process of having discussions with interested parties. The process of taking serious written offers will be the next step.
 - Pat emphasized the church's commitment to being a good neighbor and ensuring any new owner aligns with the church's mission and community values.
 - Questions from the floor:
 - There was an inquiry about the possibility of a developer buying the building and converting it into an apartment building. Pat clarified that apartment buildings are considered commercial and would require rezoning, which is unlikely under the current land use. Margaret mentioned the city's ongoing zoning rewrite and the potential for new zoning types to impact the property's future use.
 - There was a question about the lack of a "For Sale" sign at the property and Pat explained that a sign had been delayed because of the need to apply for a sign permit due to the building being in the Historic District.

- There were questions about ingress and egress, and Pat stated that the sale has been listed as: the building and the land under it. She confirmed the need for egress through the church's parking lot.
- There was a suggestion that the church consider workforce housing options, which could benefit the community and the church financially. The County is providing incentives for faith-based institutions to create workforce housing on their property, although the City of Rockville is not doing so at this point.
- There was a question about the asking price, and Pat confirmed it is \$800,000 for the unimproved building.
- There was an inquiry about a potential offer from Rainbow Place, and Pat clarified that Rainbow has expressed interest but no formal offer has been made.
- The Director of the RCPNS nursery school, housed in the building, expressed concern about the potential displacement of their facility and the impact on the community.
- There were strong expressions by residents in favor of both the RCPNS and Rainbow Place continuing with their current scope of services.
- There were also strong expressions of concern about potential expansion of Rainbow Place's scope of services at this location and resulting loss of RCPNS school.
- Pat reiterated the church's commitment to transparency and willingness to come back and update WECA, and meet with any group interested in discussing the property's future.
- Pastor Susan added that the church's national Presbyterian Authority will also review any contracts or leases to ensure they align with the church's mission.
- **Support for Impacted Federal Workers**
 - Information was presented about Rockville's wellness series for impacted federal workers, including classes, nature walks, and discounted fitness memberships.
 - The state of Maryland is also offering workshops and services to help workers find new opportunities.
 - The community is urged to take advantage of these resources and stay informed about available support.

Business Items

- **Introduction of Nominating Committee for 2025 Officer Election**
This year's Nominating Committee members are Brian Shipley, Don Hadley, and Jane Pontius. As every year, and as specified in the charter, the committee will evaluate candidates and recommend a slate of officers for the May election. Residents were invited to consider running for officer roles.
- **Treasurer's Report**
Treasurer Darlene Pierro gave the report. We started February with \$2,715 in our account. There was income of \$350 from a newsletter ad payment, and expenses of \$498, including the annual \$300 payment to the Rockville Presbyterian Church for use of meeting space. We closed with month with \$2,568 in our account. Margaret explained that our account is somewhat full right now because next month we have our largest expenditure of the year, which is the payment for the newsletter printing.

- **Public Safety Report from Rockville Police Department**

Lt. Matney provided the report, noting one burglary in the neighborhood so far this year. A concern was raised from the floor about recent burglaries with a request for detailed information on the incidents. Lt. Matney agreed to research and provide a detailed report on burglaries in the area for the next meeting, and to email a list of tools residents can use to get more information about specific incidents. The community also discussed the need for increased police presence and enforcement at problematic intersections, particularly Anderson Ave. and Mannakee St.

- **Minutes Approval**

Angela Geer moved to approve the minutes from the January meeting, which was seconded and the minutes approved by board member vote. There was an inquiry from the floor about the posting of minutes on the website, and Margaret and VP of Outreach Heidi Liu confirmed the minutes for meetings since the fall are not yet posted. We are working with technology constraints on the website and catching up.

- **Upcoming Events**

Heidi confirmed that the annual neighborhood Springfest is scheduled for May 17 at Monument Park. Residents were encouraged to contact Heidi to help out with the event!

Open Forum

The floor was opened for community concerns and questions.

- There was concern expressed with the lack of police presence at problematic intersections and a suggestion for increased enforcement. The group discussed the challenges experienced in 2024 with getting the city to address traffic and speeding issues. Margaret offered WECA's support with doing the official petition process to the city for help at Anderson and Mannakee. Lt. Matney cited manpower challenges and the recent changes in police leadership, and assured that efforts are being made to increase enforcement.
- There was discussion from the floor about the potential impact of the church's property sale on building tenants including the nursery school, and the need for transparency and community involvement. A proposal was made to invite Rainbow Place to come speak at the April WECA meeting, but there were comments from the floor that the timing for this was not right/too early.
- Margaret encouraged residents concerned about deer overpopulation to testify to the Mayor and Council at the upcoming Budget Public Hearings in support of WECA's proposal to include funds for citywide Humane Deer Population Management in the FY26 budget. A copy of WECA's proposal was provided.

Next Meeting

The next monthly neighborhood meeting will be on April 10, 2025.

Adjournment

The meeting was adjourned at 8:10 pm.